

Rabbits, hares, and pikas

Order Lagomorpha

Black-lipped pika

Ochotona curzoniae

- ↔ 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
- 📍 E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The black-lipped pika is sandy brown above and dull yellow-white on the underside, with a rust-hued patch behind the ear and a dark nose and lips. Native to the bleak, cold grasslands of the Tibetan plateau, this small, hamsterlike relative of rabbits and hares has

special physiological adaptations that help it to survive in habitats where temperatures frequently plunge well below freezing. A plant-eater, it lives in family groups that occupy a single burrow system. Some of these groups can be very large, because the females are each capable of bearing up to five litters of eight young in a season. Unlike other pika species, both parents care for the young. In some areas, this pika is so numerous as to be considered a pest.

Arctic hare

Lepus arcticus

- ↔ 17–26 in (43–66 cm)
- 📍 N. Canada, Greenland
- ⊗ Common

Specialized for life in its hostile, snowbound habitat, the Arctic hare has a thick coat of dense fur and shorter ears, reducing heat loss. In the north of its range, its coat stays white all year, but further south it turns gray-brown in summer. It eats a variety of plant material, and even carrion when food is scarce. Unlike other hares, it sometimes gathers in groups of 300 or more that move together as coordinated flocks.

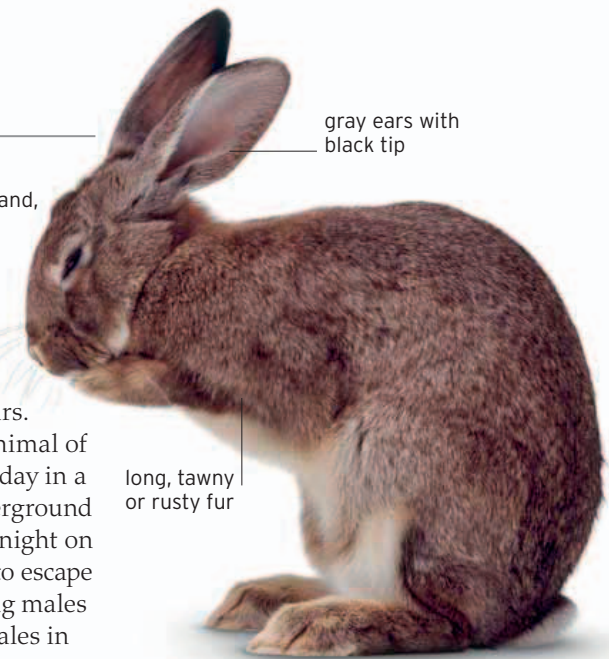


Brown hare

Lepus europaeus

- ↔ 19–28 in (48–70 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Australia, New Zealand, North and South America
- ⊗ Common

At first glance similar to a rabbit, the brown hare is bigger, with longer legs and longer, black-tipped ears. It is essentially a solitary animal of open habitats that rests by day in a hollow rather than an underground burrow. It feeds mainly by night on plants, relying on its speed to escape enemies. In spring, courting males are often fought off by females in stand-up fights.



gray ears with black tip

long, tawny or rusty fur

Eastern cottontail

Sylvilagus floridanus

- ↔ 15–20 in (38–51 cm)
- 📍 SE. Canada to Mexico, Central America, N. South America
- ⊗ Common

The most widespread and adaptable of the 13 cottontail species, the eastern cottontail usually lives in grassy areas with shrubs for cover. It eats green plants in summer, and bark and twigs in winter. Unlike the European rabbit, which it resembles, it prefers not to dig its own burrows, relying on those excavated by other animals. When breeding, it nests in a shallow depression dug among the grass, which it lines with fur.

European rabbit

Oryctolagus cuniculus

- ↔ 14–20 in (34–50 cm)
- 📍 Europe, NW. Africa, Australia, New Zealand, S. South America
- ⊗ Near threatened

Previously restricted to southwest Europe and nearby northwest Africa, the European rabbit has now been introduced throughout much of the world.

Other species

- American pika *Ochotona princeps* » p40
- Black-tailed jackrabbit *Lepus californicus* » p63

Rodents

Order Rodentia

Yellow-bellied marmot

Marmota flaviventris

- ↔ 14–20 in (34–50 cm)
- 📍 SW. Canada to W. US
- ⊗ Common

This rodent spends much of its time in a burrow and hibernates all winter. It usually feeds in the morning and late afternoon, on grasses and other low-growing plants. Each male may live with up to four females in a small colony.

Woodchuck

Marmota monax

- ↔ 13–21 in (33–53 cm)
- 📍 Alaska and W. Canada to E. Canada to E. US
- ⊗ Common

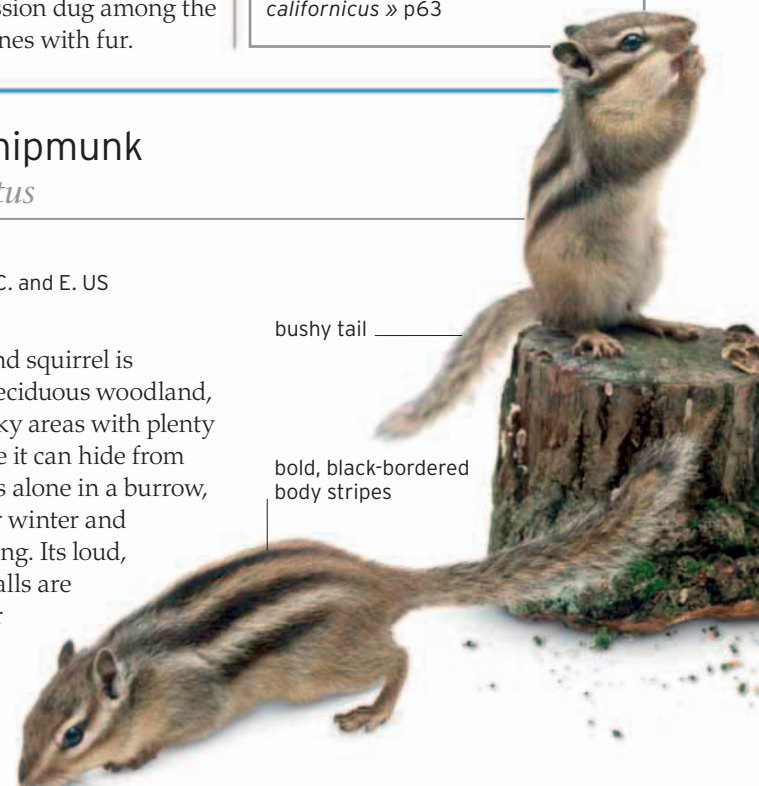
Also known as the marmot or groundhog, the woodchuck is a type of ground squirrel that favors open habitats, where it feeds on seeds, grass, fruit, and insects. In winter it retreats to a deep burrow to hibernate. When they emerge, rival males often fight for dominance, and a woodchuck will defend its burrow by threatening trespassers with chattering, bared teeth.

Eastern chipmunk

Tamias striatus

- ↔ 6 in (15.2 cm)
- 📍 SE. Canada to C. and E. US
- ⊗ Common

This small ground squirrel is widespread in deciduous woodland, especially in rocky areas with plenty of crevices where it can hide from predators. It lives alone in a burrow, hibernating over winter and emerging in spring. Its loud, staccato alarm calls are valuable to other small animals, alerting them to predators.



bushy tail

bold, black-bordered body stripes